Effective without Warrant: Causal-Normative Networks and the Social Life of Status

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25th May 2026

Abstract

Social statuses can be effective without being morally warranted. A person wrongly treated as a promisor may face demand, blame, and legal pressure; an unjust classification may be taken up by a field as a real standing. Extending Khalidi (2018)'s account of projectible kinds as ordered nodes in causal networks, I argue that social and institutional statuses are projectible in a CAUSAL-NORMATIVE NETWORK. Such networks join causal uptake, status transition, recognition, and constitutive ties. They explain how statuses are generated, bound to correlative positions, tracked, and taken up, while keeping apart social efficacy, field-validity, and moral warrant. Misrecognition and discrimination are diagnostic because they show an assignment becoming socially effective, and even field-valid, without becoming morally warranted.

1 The problem of mixed explanation

Dickens gives the problem its comic legal form in *Bardell v. Pickwick*: a misconstrued exchange becomes an action for breach of promise, then a damages verdict, and then Fleet Prison.[1] Put abstractly, suppose a community or court comes to treat someone as having promised when he hasn't, or as bound by a debt he never incurred. The treatment is not imaginary: he is asked to pay, blamed when he refuses, distrusted, perhaps shut out. But if the promise was never made, those responses lack the obligation they purport to answer to; the demand has the social force of a warranted demand without its warrant. Cases of this sort generalize: some social statuses are real in their effects without being morally warranted; some are valid within a field without being just. Explaining how that is possible is the problem of this paper.

Identifying status with treatment makes the wrongly-hounded man indistinguishable from a genuine debtor. Treating status as only a rule-bound normative fact makes the hounding irrelevant. The case needs both pieces: a normative position, and a causal uptake that can fit that position or fail to. It also needs three assessments kept apart: whether the assignment is effective, field-valid, and morally warranted.

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[1] In *The Pickwick Papers*, Mrs Bardell's action lays damages at £1,500, the jury awards £750, and Pickwick's refusal to pay carries him toward imprisonment for debt (Dickens, 1837, chaps. 26, 34, 40–41).

Promising is the case I work through, because its life-cycle is familiar and its parts are clean: an act creates an obligation, the obligation is recognized and relied on, breach sets off demand and repair, release cancels the profile. And the same shape recurs in consent, in official judgment, and, most systematically, in discrimination, where an assignment that's effective, and even valid within its field, hardens into a regime that morality disowns (Section 6). I keep to promising until then.

False promise and discrimination pull the model in different directions. In the false-promise case, the status fails to obtain and recognition answers to nothing. In the discriminatory case, the standing may be genuinely conferred and real while remaining unwarranted. Promising is the clean entry case, not the template for both.

The model rests on four kinds of dependence, three of them directed edges and the fourth a non-directed constitutive tie.

First, CAUSAL DEPENDENCE: one event, disposition, procedure, response, record, sanction, or expectation helps produce another. A public promise causes reliance; a judgment causes enforcement; a recognition state causally drives treatment, and that uptake is where much of the network's efficacy lies.

Second, CONSTITUTIVE DEPENDENCE: one deontic position is the correlative of another within a single complex. A duty and the claim-right held against the duty-bearer are one jural relation under two descriptions, so from either one reads off the other (Hohfeld, 1913). The tie is constitutive, not causal.

Third, NORMATIVE-TRANSITION DEPENDENCE: a performance, rule, status, or transition event generates, blocks, terminates, defeats, or modifies a status. An undertaking generates a duty; release terminates it; withdrawal terminates a permission; breach generates a secondary profile of demand, blame, apology, repair, or excuse.

Fourth, RECOGNITIONAL DEPENDENCE: a belief, record, uptake, or official classification purports to track a status, fitting it, misfitting it, or answering to no status at all. But what recognition then drives is causal uptake: demand, sanction, reliance, exclusion. Where recognition is authorized to make the status it records, as a court judgment makes a liability, the case is compound: recognition plus transition.

These four dependence types describe the structure of the network. They don't yet say whether a status-assignment is valid. Validity is assessed across the network: an assignment may be effective when recognition and uptake fire, field-valid when it satisfies the rules of a practice, and morally warranted when it has the right moral basis.

A FIELD here is a normative practice, interpersonal morality, contract law, medicine, with its own repertoire of statuses and conditions for generating them; Section 7 treats it as a homeostatic cluster of those conditions and the mechanisms that stabilize them. Much of what follows turns on the fact that efficacy, field-validity, and moral warrant usually travel together but needn't (Sections 6 and 7).

2 Why ordinary causal networks aren't enough

One tempting simplification is to treat causal-normative networks as ordinary causal networks with moral labels added. The best reason to try that comes from Khalidi (2018). Khalidi takes projectibility as the mark of a kind: if something is gold, one can infer its melting point, density, conductivity, and other properties; if something is merely dirt, the label tells us much less. A kind matters for explanation when membership supports such inferences.

For Khalidi, those inferences work because the properties are ordered, not because they merely travel together. Gold's atomic structure explains many of its other properties. A directed causal graph captures that order: change one property in the right way, hold the rest fixed, and another property shifts. The functionless widget fails because its properties form a heap rather than an ordered pattern.

That point should be preserved. Projection needs order. The question is whether all useful order in the moral and institutional domain is causal order.

Promises make the limit visible. Suppose Nora promises to return a borrowed book on Friday. From the promise we can project several things: Owen has a claim, Nora owes performance, Owen may rely, breach may license demand or apology. Some of those projections are causal. Nora's words may cause Owen not to buy another copy. But the duty and the claim-right aren't cause and effect; they are the same promissory relation viewed from two sides.

Release makes the point again. If Owen releases Nora on Thursday, the same Friday non-return no longer counts as a breach. The release needn't cause the non-return, the book, or Nora's later conduct. It changes what the later non-performance amounts to. That dependence is directed, since release changes breach status and not the other way around, and it supports projection from release to the absence of liability or repair. But it isn't causal in Khalidi's sense.

Consent has the same shape. A patient signs a consent form before a procedure. The signed form may causally move many things: a nurse updates the chart, the surgeon schedules the room, the anaesthetist prepares the drugs. But the permission relation is not just that causal chain. If the patient withdraws consent before the procedure, the same incision changes status. It is no longer permitted treatment but a wrong. The withdrawal orders the later facts, because it changes what the later act is, even if some staff do not hear about it and the causal machinery keeps moving.

The extension to Khalidi is narrow. Projectibility still requires order. In moral and institutional cases, some of the order is carried by normative transitions and recognitional links rather than by causal mechanisms alone. Section 4 builds that typed network; the present point is only that ordinary causal networks are too narrow, not that order was the wrong demand.

3 Why normative taxonomies aren't enough

The opposite simplification keeps the normative structure and strips away the causal uptake. That is tempting too. Analytic jurisprudence has mapped much of the structure: Hohfeld (1913) sorts deontic positions into correlatives and opposites, claim and duty, power and liability. A taxonomy in this style can say that a promise generates an obligation, consent a permission, release a termination, and breach a license to complain.

That taxonomy is indispensable, but it is not yet an explanation of projection in practice. Suppose Nora fails to return the book. The taxonomy says she has breached and that Owen may complain. It doesn't say whether Owen notices, whether the complaint is taken up, whether Nora apologizes or offers an excuse, whether repair follows, or whether trust changes between them.

Those further regularities are what make promise-breaking projectible as a social kind. Breach has a recognizable place in a life-cycle: registration, demand, excuse or apology, repair or sanction, revised trust. The status starts the sequence, but the sequence runs through recognition and causal uptake.

Official judgment makes the same point in a more formal register. A taxonomy can say that a judgment creates liability, preclusion, or a remedial profile. But what makes judgment projectible in practice is also the file, the docket entry, the enforcement routine, the attorney's letter, the threat of contempt, and the debtor's changed bargaining position. Those are not further deontic implications written into the word "judgment"; they are the ordinary uptake by which a legal status becomes socially and institutionally effective.

This is why a purely normative taxonomy is too thin. A status no one could recognize, rely on, or enforce would support no social projection at all. It would still be a status, but it would not explain the patterned responses by which promise-breaking, consent withdrawal, judgment, or discriminatory ascription become stable objects of expectation.

The two reductions now fail from opposite sides. Causal order alone was too narrow; normative order alone is too thin. The explanatory unit is neither causal regularity nor normative status by itself, but a normative position coupled to causal uptake. Section 6 turns to the cases in which the two come apart.

4 The typed-edge model

If the explanatory unit is a normative position coupled to causal uptake, the graph has to show both parts. In the promise case it must show the obligation and claim-right; otherwise the wrongness of demand is lost. It must also show uptake, reliance, demand, and repair; otherwise the promise has no social life.

I keep Khalidi (2018)'s picture of a kind as a highly connected node in a directed graph, but I let the edges differ in type. The vertices are property instances and states; the edges are typed relations of dependence.[2]

The graph is not a new layer of metaphysics. Nora's duty is grounded by her undertaking under the rules of the relevant field; Owen's claim-right is the correlative position; Owen's reliance is an ordinary causal effect; his recognition is a representation of the duty. The network displays those relations together. It doesn't replace the grounding story, which is anchored in the field (Epstein, 2015).

To draw such a graph, start with the explanatory question. If the question is why Owen may demand performance, the duty and claim-right matter. If the question is why Nora is shunned despite never promising, the false recognition and its causal uptake matter. If the question is why a court order leads to enforcement, the judgment and the enforcement machinery matter.

The node types are simple. Performances include utterances, signed documents, actions, and omissions. Statuses include obligation, permission, power, liability, immunity, and standing. Transition events include undertaking, authorization, release, withdrawal, breach, and defeat. Recognition states include belief, record, official classification, and uptake. Response states include blame, resentment, apology, repair, sanction, and trust revision. A field is not another node; it fixes which of these items count.

The carrying cases fill those slots in familiar ways. In a promise, the undertaking generates a duty; recognition by the promisee or audience helps drive reliance, demand, apology, repair, and trust revision. In consent, giving or withdrawing consent changes a permission profile, while recognition

[2] Formally, this is a typed-edge relational structure: node labels for kinds, edge labels for dependence types, with well-formed cases fixed by constraints on configurations. In a formal treatment of English syntax, Pullum and Rogers (2008) use node-labelled categories and edge-labelled functions. Nothing in the argument depends on the analogy; it only marks the intended level of formal abstraction. Pullum and Scholz (2001) set out the model-theoretic stance.

determines whether others proceed, stop, complain, or apologize. In a judgment, the court's act is both an official recognition and a status-altering event, with records, enforcement, and remedies downstream. In discrimination, an ascription or signal drives uptake of a social classification, and that uptake can lead to exclusion, sanction, or loss of credibility.

Consider the promise graph as a drawing exercise. Nora's utterance goes in because it can generate the duty and cause reliance. The duty goes in because it is what Owen's demand purports to answer to. Owen's uptake goes in because demand and repair usually pass through his recognition of the promise. The weather, Nora's mood, and the room's acoustics stay out unless they matter to the explanatory question. If the question is only why Owen relied, acoustics may matter; if the question is whether Nora owed performance, they usually do not.

Now change the case. Suppose Nora never promised, but Owen misheard a joke as an undertaking. The graph should not silently insert a duty node to make sense of Owen's anger. It should show Owen's recognition state and its causal downstream: demand, blame, distrust. The absent duty is part of the explanation, because it is why the demand misfires. A purely causal graph would see only Owen's anger; a purely normative taxonomy would see only the absence of duty. The mixed graph shows both.

The admission rule is practical: add a node only if leaving it out would make the explanation worse. A performance enters when it can generate, alter, defeat, or causally move a status, recognition, or response. A status enters when the field's conditions make it obtain. If the dispute is whether the status obtains, as with Pickwick's alleged promise, the graph may mark the candidate as absent rather than draw it as an ordinary status node.

The same discipline applies to edges. Draw a causal edge only where one item helps produce another. Draw a normative-transition edge only where a performance, rule, status, or transition event generates, terminates, blocks, defeats, or modifies a status. Draw a constitutive tie only where two positions are one relation under two descriptions. Draw a recognitional edge only where recognition fits an actual status node.

That last rule matters. In a false-promise case, demand doesn't prove a duty. The graph should show a recognition node with live causal uptake and no fitting recognitional edge to an actual duty. Nor should moral warrant appear as a further status node that causes legitimacy; warrant is an assessment of the assignment. And the duty–claim-right tie should not be replaced with a causal arrow, since correlatives are not two states linked by a mechanism.

The network's four dependence types fall into three directed edges, causal, normative-transition, and recognitional, and the non-directed constitutive ties among deontic correlatives. Two further notions sit just outside the inventory. *Authorized recognition* is the court-order case: a judgment records a liability and, because the field authorizes the court to do so, creates a new procedural status. *Projection* is what the graph is for: using one point in the network to make defeasible inferences about what else should hold or what will happen next.

The edge types are told apart by their behaviour under intervention or analogous counterfactual probes, reserving *intervention* in the strict Woodwardian sense for causal edges. Woodward (2003) counts a relation as causal when some possible intervention on the first variable changes the second while everything else is held fixed, and the change reaches the second only through the first (Woodward, 2014).

A causal edge passes this test in the ordinary way: intervene on the utterance and reliance shifts, intervene on the judgment and enforcement follows. Khalidi already reads his own causal edges this way (Khalidi, 2018), which is why typing the edges extends his picture rather than breaking with it.

A constitutive tie fails the test in a way that helps mark its type. A duty and its correlative claim-right aren't two states linked by a mechanism; they're one jural relation under two descriptions (Hohfeld, 1913). No intervention changes the duty while holding the claim-right fixed, because changing the one just is changing the other: the change doesn't reach the claim-right only through the duty, it lands on both at once. By Woodward's own criterion the tie isn't causal, and that failure is what marks it as constitutive.

The transition and recognitional edges are directed without being causal. A normative-transition edge runs from a performance, rule, status, or transition event to the status it generates, terminates, blocks, defeats, or modifies: release the promisor and the same non-performance is no longer a breach.

A recognitional edge connects an actual status node to a recognition node that fits it. A belief, record, or classification, itself driven by signals and cues along causal edges, may also misfit or answer to no status at all. In those failed cases the recognition node remains, with its outgoing causal edges, but the fitting recognitional edge is absent or failed. That gap is what the "mis-" in misrecognition marks.

One occurrence can also enter more than one relation. The same utterance "I'll do it" may causally induce reliance, generate a duty if made under the right conditions, and become the object of later recognition. The same court order can be evidence in one setting, an operative change in another, and the cause of enforcement in a third. A racialized name on a resume is different again: it is not the status it signals, but a cue that causally moves recognition, which then moves callback behavior.

When representation succeeds the recognition tracks its status (Figure 1); whether it fits is separate from what it sets off, since the uptake to treatment, demand, sanction, reliance, exclusion is causal, the point where the normative layer re-enters the causal one.

An illocutionary act, in Sbisà (2023)'s terms, assigns or cancels deontic-modal predicates, and so appears here as a performance feeding a normative-transition edge.

Figure 1 renders a promise as a small network of this kind, with the four edge types that recur across the carrying cases.

Two conditions keep such a graph from sliding back into a mere list of properties. First, inference has to respect edge type, since each licenses a different inference: causal prediction (enforcement from a judgment), constitutive read-off (a claim-right from a duty), transition projection (a secondary duty or liability from a breach), and recognitional expectation (uptake from a recognition), none to be treated as though it were another.

Second, every status that figures in explanation has to be reachable by response states through recognition and its causal uptake; a status that could not be recognized or taken up within any practice explains no projectible social cascade (the argument of Section 3).

With those conditions in place the graph carries order in Khalidi's sense, projection along directed edges, while generalizing what that order is: not causal dependence throughout, but directed dependence of three kinds, causal, normative-transition, and recognitional, running within constitutive constraints.

All these nodes and edges are field-indexed: which performances count, which recognitions are authoritative, and which responses are licensed depends on the field, to which Section 7 returns.

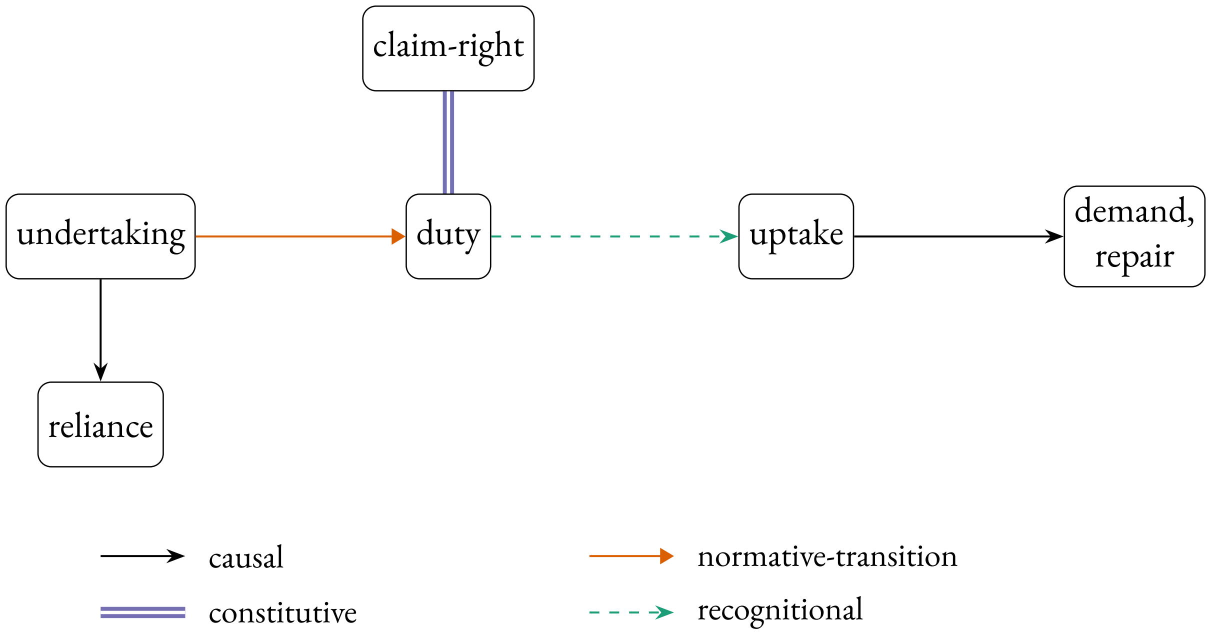

Figure 1: A promise as a causal-normative network. The undertaking generates the duty (a normative transition) and causally induces reliance; the duty carries its correlative claim-right (a constitutive tie, drawn without an arrowhead, since correlatives are one relation under two descriptions, not a directed cause); the duty is tracked by recognition, whose uptake causally drives demand and repair (the recognitional arrow is drawn in the fitting case; in failed cases the recognition node remains without a fitting edge, Section 4). The four edge types are keyed below the graph.

5 Coupling and counterfactual signatures

The easiest way to see the coupling is to ask simple what-if questions. What if Owen releases Nora? What if Owen mistakenly believes Nora promised? What if a court enters judgment? Each change moves a different part of the graph, and the pattern tells us which kind of edge is doing the work. I call these patterns *signatures*. I reserve *intervention* for the genuinely causal edges, where Woodward's apparatus applies directly.

The first what-if changes a status or the rule behind it. Release the promisor and later non-performance is no longer a breach; the demand, blame, and repair that breach would license lapse with it. Withdraw consent and the same act of touching changes from permitted to wrongful. Speak without standing and the same words fail to bind; an official's words and a bystander's words don't have the same status effects. These are the status-altering acts the normative-powers literature describes (Owens, 2012; Raz, 2022).

Call that a STATUS-RULE SIGNATURE. The status node changes first in the order of explanation, and uptake follows because agents now have a different status to recognize or answer to. The audience may be psychologically unchanged at the first moment: Owen may still expect the book, the doctor may still prepare the procedure, the clerk may still open the file. What has changed is what their responses would now be responses to.

The consent example is useful because the surface behavior can remain almost unchanged. A clinician reaches for the same instrument, at the same time, for the same medical reason. Before withdrawal, that act is within the permission profile. After withdrawal, the same act of touching is no longer licensed. If the clinician has not heard the withdrawal, her recognition node may still represent the old permission, and her action may continue along the old causal path. The status-rule signature and the recognition signature come apart in one ordinary case.

The second what-if changes recognition while the status stays put. Suppose Nora never promised, but Owen and the audience believe she did. There is no promise-duty node for recognition to fit, but the false recognition node can still drive demand, blame, and loss of trust. Suppose consent has been withdrawn but the withdrawal is not registered. The permission profile has changed, but the old response path may keep running.

Call this a RECOGNITION SIGNATURE. The recognition node may fit the status, misfit it, or answer to no status at all. Either way, the causal edge leaving the recognition node can fire. In hiring, changing the employer's belief about an applicant's gender changes the recognition node and the causal edge from recognition to callback while leaving the applicant and the moral facts unchanged. Woodward's own reading of "being a woman causes hiring discrimination" relocates the cause to the employer's beliefs about the applicant's gender (Woodward, 2014): a recognition signature in the present sense, explaining efficacy without settling warrant.

The third what-if is the compound case. A judgment records, finds, or accepts a status, but the field also gives that act a power to change the status profile. Before judgment, the alleged liability may be disputed. After judgment, a new procedural and remedial status exists even where the court is mistaken. A registration can create the record that counts; an accepted resignation can end the office (American Law Institute, 1981).

This is AUTHORIZED RECOGNITION. It is not a fifth primitive. The same node occupies two roles: recognition, because it records or finds; transition, because the field authorizes that recognition to make a status difference.

Pickwick again shows why the compound matters. The alleged proposal does not by itself create the promised obligation. But the verdict does create a legal liability within the procedure of the court. That liability can then be entered, collected, resisted, or enforced. One mistake is to say that the judgment merely recognizes a liability that was already there. Another is to say that the judgment is just a cause of imprisonment. It is both recognition and status transition: a finding that the field treats as operative.

These signatures depend on a separability assumption. We must be able, at least in explanation, to change one node or edge while holding the adjacent structure fixed. Woodward calls this MODULARITY: mechanisms are separately disruptable in principle (Woodward, 2003). The condition is not trivial. In an actual field, rules, records, and uptake often move together, which is why the signatures are explanatory probes rather than field experiments.

Constitutive ties fail that separability condition. One can't change a duty while holding the correlative claim-right fixed, since the two are one relation under two descriptions. The status-rule and recognition contrasts pass. Release the promisor and the obligation lapses while the audience's belief can remain; change an employer's belief while the applicant's status remains. Modularity sorts the edge types rather than flattening them.

I set aside a pure causal intervention, such as severing an uptake mechanism so the letter never arrives, because both reductive views already grant it. It can't tell the reductive views apart from the coupled account.

The status-rule and recognition signatures expose the mistake in the forced choice. The recognition reduction predicts that enough uptake turns the recognition node into the status node. The normative reduction keeps the status node but treats misfiring recognition and its causal effects as noise. False promise shows why both are wrong: demand may be real without a duty, and the absence of duty still matters.

The point carries across the cases. A causal graph with moral labels can't explain release, because labels don't change breach status. A normative taxonomy with sociology appended can't explain false uptake, because it has nowhere to put efficacy without warrant. The coupled, typed structure is needed because it predicts which part of the case moves and which part holds fixed.

An interventionist objection presses from the other direction. Why not drop the network label and disambiguate everything into manipulations of beliefs, records, and behavior? The reply turns on Woodward's own view that interventionism is methodology, not ontology (Woodward, 2014). It clarifies causal claims by tying them to hypothetical experiments; it doesn't say that every relation clarified in that way is causal.

The promise case shows the difference. Release the promisor and the obligation node lapses, even if the audience keeps believing that the promisor owes performance. Change the audience's belief instead, and demand or blame may move while the duty does not. Both probes need the status node: without it, one can record who demanded what, but not whether the demand fitted an obligation.

The same point holds for discrimination. If a correspondence study changes the employer's belief, it identifies a causal path from signal to recognition to callback. It doesn't settle whether the belief fits the applicant's social status, or whether the status assignment has warrant. The interventionist disambiguation is useful, but it marks rather than removes the place where a normative edge is needed.

6 Misrecognition as the diagnostic case

Misrecognition is the sharpest diagnostic because it asks a plain question: what should we say when people treat someone as bound, liable, authorized, dangerous, or disqualified, and that treatment is wrong? A recognition-only account says the treatment makes the status. A purely normative account says the treatment is noise around the real status. Neither answer fits Pickwick, who is effectively hounded as a promisor without having made the promise.

The network separates three questions. Is the assignment socially effective? That is a question about uptake: do people rely, demand, enforce, exclude, record, or sanction? Is it field-valid? That is a question about the field's own generating conditions: the right party, office, procedure, form, record, or rule. Is it morally warranted? That is a question about whether the assignment has the right moral basis.

Those questions often receive the same answer. A genuine promise may be recognized, valid in the relevant practice, and morally binding. But they can come apart. A crowd may demand performance where no promise was made. A court may impose liability by a valid procedure on a mistaken record. An unjust practice may confer a standing that its own field treats as valid while morality rejects the standing itself.

It helps to keep the columns separate. In the false-promise case, social efficacy is present if people demand and blame, but field-validity and moral warrant are absent if no undertaking occurred. In the mistaken-judgment case, efficacy is present and legal field-validity may also be present, even though the underlying finding is wrong. In the discrimination case, a community may confer a degraded standing that is socially real and field-stabilized, while the moral-warrant column remains empty.

This gives three failure profiles. In *false recognition*, uptake occurs although the assignment is neither field-valid nor morally warranted. Pickwick's alleged promise is the comic case. In *wrongful field-validity*, the assignment satisfies a field's rules but lacks moral warrant. Wrongful conferral of a degraded standing is the central case below. In *suppressed entitlement*, the moral basis is present but the field refuses recognition, as when a person has a claim that the institution declines to register.

Pickwick is useful because it keeps the first failure profile clean. Until judgment enters, there is no promised obligation for recognition to fit. The verdict then changes the case: it is an authorized recognition that creates a new legal liability. The episode shows efficacy without the promised obligation, but it does not yet show the regime structure of wrongful conferral.

Regime cases require more than one mistaken uptake. A person wrongly believed to have promised faces a local failure: demand, blame, and distrust may be real, but the error can in principle be corrected by showing that no promise was made. A durable discriminatory practice is different. It repeats the ascription, routes it through records and expectations, and gives people real constraints and enablements under that description.

Ásta's conferralist account helps specify that second structure. A social status is conferred on a person because others take them to have some base property, whether or not they actually have it, and the status consists in real constraints and enablements on what they may do (Ásta, 2018). The ascribed standing is not a mere belief. It is a social position with teeth.

Conferralism might seem to collapse the distinction I need. If the status just is what gets conferred, then enough recognition constitutes the status. But the collapse is avoided once the assessment questions are separated. Conferral can make a communal status real and effective without making it morally warranted. A discriminatory standing can be genuinely conferred, field-stabilized, and morally indefensible at the same time.

Some oppression works through this route: morally indefensible status-ascriptions become socially effective, and often field-valid, along durable recognition and response pathways. Not all oppression does. Much is material, distributive, or coercive rather than recognitional, the pressure the redistribution-versus-recognition debate brings to bear (Fraser & Honneth, 2003). Stabilized wrongful conferral is only the case this account is built to diagnose.

Read Figure 2 from left to right. An ascription generates an ascribed standing. That standing is recognized and taken up. Uptake drives exclusion or sanction, and those responses cause harm. The grey moral-warrant annotation says that the standing can be live in the field while lacking the moral basis that would justify it.

Discrimination, where it runs through conferred standing, is that regime case. The efficacy is measurable, if crudely. In the correspondence study by Bertrand and Mullainathan (2004, pp. 997–998), otherwise-matched resumes with White-sounding names drew about 50% more callbacks than those with African-American-sounding names (9.65% against 6.45%), and Ayres (1991) found parallel differential treatment in retail car negotiations.

These studies show patterned uptake. A name or other raced signifier sends a causal edge to a recognition node, and that recognition node sends causal edges to callbacks, prices, warnings, searches, or other outcomes. A normative taxonomy with no place for this efficacy can't describe what's happening.

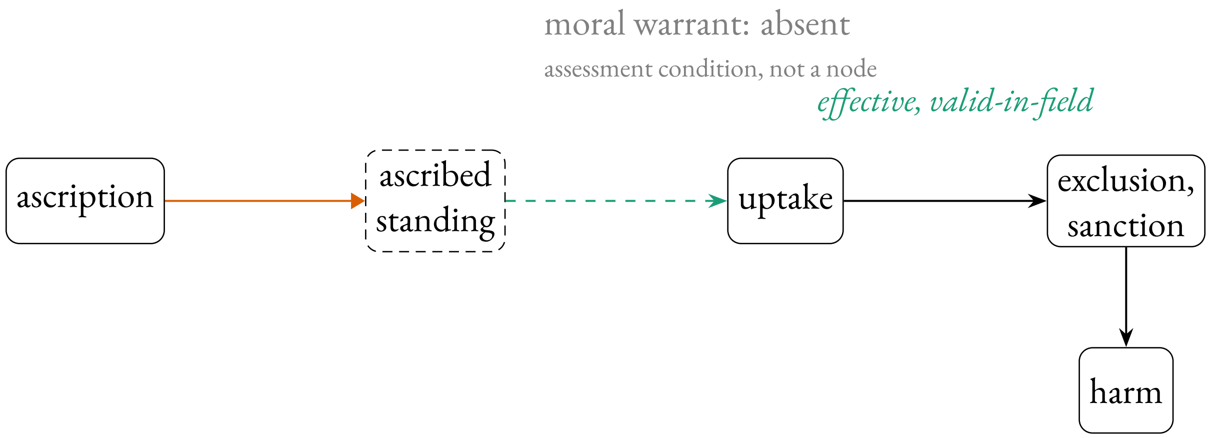

Figure 2: Wrongful conferral. An ascription generates an ascribed standing. Recognition and uptake then drive exclusion, sanction, and downstream harm. The standing may be valid by the field's rules, but moral warrant is absent (grey annotation). This is not the false-promise case, where recognition fails to fit an absent status, but a real conferred standing without moral warrant. Edge styles as in Figure 1.

The studies do not manipulate race itself. As Weinberger (2023) observes, they manipulate a *signal* for race: the name matters because it reliably tracks race, and the experiment varies the signal to mimic what it would be were the candidate of another race, leaving the candidate's race untouched. That is a localized causal test of the signal-recognition-response pathway. It does not make race an ordinary manipulable cause, and it does not reduce race to its signals.

Detection is still not an account of discrimination. Kohler-Hausmann (2019) is right that a signal test can show race made a difference without saying what race is or why discriminating on it is wrong. Hu (forthcoming) presses further: deciding which differences between two candidates constitute rather than confound the effect of race already takes a normative stand, so even the measurement presupposes the normative layer.

What turns biased uptake into conferred standing is entrenchment. A single misfiring is false recognition. A stable recognition-response pathway is different. When the pathway is repeated, recorded, expected, and field-licensed, it shapes what one may do, where, with what credibility, and at what risk. That imposed structure, not the bare frequency of mistreatment, is the degraded standing (Ásta, 2018).

The contrast is between an episode and a position. A single employer's biased callback decision is an episode of differential treatment. It may be wrongful, and it may reveal a causal pathway from signal to recognition to response. A standing emerges when decisions of that sort become mutually reinforcing: employers expect other employers to read the signal the same way, applicants adjust their applications in anticipation, institutions record and route outcomes accordingly, and the burden becomes part of what one must navigate. The graph then has a stable ascribed-standing node, not just repeated arrows from signal to harm.

The discrimination this account captures is entrenched wrongful conferral: recognitional and causal edges firing reliably enough to be projectible, fixing a degraded standing that a field's rules may even license but morality doesn't. Other discrimination need not run through conferred standing. Resource allocation, exclusionary design, and statistical sorting can wrong without conferring a degraded status. The present account claims only the conferral-based cases.

The route to wrongful conferral begins with the recognition signature of Section 5. At the audit-study stage, one can vary a signal or recognition node and watch uptake move while the applicant and moral facts hold fixed. But wrongful conferral adds a further step. Once that recognition-response pathway is entrenched and field-licensed, it helps generate a degraded standing rather than merely misrecognizing one. Only a coupled, typed structure registers both moments: the recognition is real and effective, and the standing it helps stabilize remains unwarranted.

7 Fields

A field tells the graph what counts. In contract law it tells us which words, signatures, consideration, defects, and releases generate or defeat liability (American Law Institute, 1981). In medicine it tells us who may consent, who may diagnose, which records count, and which responses follow. In ordinary promising it tells us when an undertaking is serious enough to bind and what apology or repair would answer to breach.

The same surface event can receive different treatment across fields. Saying "I promise" at dinner may create an interpersonal obligation; saying the same words in a negotiation may be legally idle without the right form or consideration; saying them as part of a joke may create no obligation at all. A signature on a consent form may authorize treatment in a clinic, but a similar signature on a petition does not. The field supplies the relevant repertoire of statuses and the rules for moving among them.

These items do not hang together by accident. Records, registers, monitoring, enforcement routines, reputational sanction, professional training, and habituated uptake hold them in place. A field, on this view, is a homeostatic property cluster (Boyd, 1999): a bundle of co-stabilizing norms and practices, not a sharp rule-set. The appeal to homeostasis is explanatory rather than taxonomic: field parameters stabilize together, but the claim is not that fields form natural kinds in Boyd's full sense.

That matters because fields are rarely tidy. A counter-practice may reject an official rule without leaving the domain altogether. Oppressive and resistant uptake can coexist in the same workplace, clinic, court, or community. The field has fuzzy and contested edges, but it can still stabilize enough conditions to make some assignments count as field-valid.

Field-validity is not the same as current recognition. A contract can be valid even if a particular audience misses it; a release can terminate an obligation even if the promisee still demands performance; an unjust classification can be treated as valid by a field whose rules are themselves morally defective. The field fixes the conditions; recognition is one route by which agents track or fail to track them.

This is why the field parameterizes the network rather than sitting inside it as another node. It fixes the repertoire of statuses, the performances that generate them, the authorities that may alter them, the records that preserve them, the recognitions that count, the responses that are licensed, and the defeats that block or end them.

Field-parameterization lets the account steer between universalism and relativism: one shared typed network, many field-specific parameterizations. (I use "field" for a normative practice or setting, not in Bourdieu's technical sense.) What anchors a field's parameters is a further question: in Epstein

(2015)'s terms, the frame principles that fix a status's grounding conditions are themselves anchored, and the homeostatic mechanisms just described are part of what anchors them.

Fields come in at least two kinds. Institutional fields assign status functions by authorized conferral; Searle (1995) builds these from the assignment of function, collective intentionality, and constitutive rules. A contract, diagnosis, judgment, or accepted resignation lives here, and so does authorized recognition. Speech-act practice also belongs here when an illocutionary act alters the deontic-modal position of participants (Sbisà, 2023).

Communal fields work differently. Ásta (2018) marks out statuses conferred by a community with the standing to confer but by no single office, gender and race among them. That distinction explains why official judgment and discrimination, though both turn on recognition, behave so differently. The first is institutional: a recognition the field authorizes to make the status it records. The second is communal: a diffuse conferral with real constraints and enablements but no authorizing office, which is just why its standing can be socially effective while lacking moral warrant.

8 Conclusion

The paper began with cases in which a person is treated as occupying a status he does not have, or is assigned a standing that a field treats as valid while morality rejects it. A causal graph can track the hounding, sanction, or exclusion. It cannot by itself say why the treatment fails to fit. A normative taxonomy can state the duty, permission, or standing. It cannot by itself explain why uptake becomes socially real.

The point is not to abandon Khalidi's causal-network account of kinds. Khalidi was right that projection needs order, not concatenation. The moral and institutional cases show that the order can be carried by non-causal edges and still support projection.

A causal-normative network has to do two jobs. Its edge types explain how statuses are generated, bound to correlative positions, tracked, and causally taken up. Its assessment vocabulary says whether the resulting assignment is socially effective, valid within a field, morally warranted, or some unstable combination of these. That is what lets the account describe misrecognition, and at regime scale the standing oppressive law renders effective and even field-valid while leaving it morally unwarranted.

The framework is not merely a reminder that some networks contain both causal and normative relations. Its stronger claim is that some explanations are unavailable unless the two are represented together. Where the boundaries of a field fall, whose recognition is authorized within it, and which misrecognitions harden into regimes are questions the framework poses rather than settles. Those questions mark the next stage of the project.

Acknowledgements

This paper was drafted with the assistance of large language models. All content has been reviewed and revised by the author, who takes full responsibility for the final text.

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